



New calling: A former Ghatak soldier, Ajay Singh now competes in the 400m as a blade runner in para athletics.

"Now, whatever is needed is provided. We have strength and conditioning experts, physiotherapists, and funding for domestic and international competition, including athlete classification. Running blades cost over Rs. 3 lakh, and sockets need replacement every few years. Soldiers cannot afford that themselves, but the Army provides whatever is required."

The recruiting pool, however, remains consistent. "Every soldier who joins has suffered an injury in service. About 90 per cent are battle casualties, most from mine blasts. Others have lost limbs or suffered paralysis due to falls, road accidents on duty, or complications from high-altitude service," says Mehta.

Notably, injury is common even among leadership. Every commanding officer of the unit has

been injured on duty. Mehta himself lost part of his right hand to splinter fragments early in his career.

These soldiers are fitted with prosthetics at the ALC in Pune, where they are identified by coaches, officials and former athletes. Some, like World Championships medallist Rana, are immediately keen. "I'd been an Army champion boxer. After losing my right leg to a mine blast in 2006, I knew para sports existed, but I didn't know how to pursue it. It was only during a prosthetic refitting in 2016 that I was introduced to Gaurav Dutta sir," says Rana.

Choosing a sport

Others were initially reluctant. "When I came to the ALC, my thinking was: I've already lost my leg for the country. *Bohot ragda kha liya hai* (I've had to struggle a great deal). Now I want to rest," says Ajay Kumar, who lost his right foot to a mine blast while patrolling in no man's land along the Line of Control.

Eventually, he reconsidered. Posted back to his unit depot, Ajay

was assigned kitchen and office duties. A graduate of the Army Commando Course in Belgaum, he longed for something more. "I didn't want to spend the rest of my service cutting vegetables. I needed something else to do. That's when I decided to call and join the Node," he says. Once inducted, coaches assess which events best suit each athlete, keeping medal prospects in mind. "We are now part of the Mission Olympic wing. Our purpose is clear. We are not here for charity. We are here to win medals," says Mehta. "We recruit younger soldiers and try to place them where we have the best chance of success. For instance, we already have exceptional shot putters. Rather than adding another, it may make sense to strengthen other events." Injury type also plays a role. "I couldn't be a runner because my stump blisters easily if I wear a running blade too long. So I took up long jump," says Solairaj.

Some athletes, however, insist on charting their own path. Ajay, despite suggestions that he take up throwing events, chose to run the 400m.

"Being a blade runner is extremely tough. In cold weather, the stump goes numb. In heat, the skin peels. *Zameen asman ka farak hota hai* (There's a world of difference) between running on two legs and as a blade runner. Sometimes the blade nut comes loose. Sometimes I fall. But I was always clear I wanted to run. I had run 40km with a loaded backpack in the commando course. As blade runners, we learn to live with pain. I'm in the Army. My motivation stays high," he says.

Making sportspersons out of soldiers

Even after recruitment, the transition is demanding. "Most soldiers here have never competed in sport before. Many are in their mid-20s or older. Other para athletes usually start younger. Soldiers also have families and responsibilities that non-Army athletes may not," says Subedar Murtaza Hossain, a former Asian Championships medallist and coach at the Node since its inception.